



AN ECS PHOTO-ESSAY

Stone & Light

The architecture, interiors and galleries of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Vastu Sangrahalaya, Mumbai

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Mumbai's great museum, in four numbers

1905

Foundation stone laid by the
Prince of Wales, 11 November

1922

Opened on 10 January,
inaugurated by Lady Lloyd

50,000

Objects, approximately,
across art, archaeology and
natural history

3 acres

Site in South Mumbai, near the
Gateway of India

02 · THE MUSEUM

From Prince of Wales Museum to CSMVS

Founded by the citizens of Bombay, with government support, to mark the Prince of Wales's 1905 visit. It was renamed in 1998 after Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj.

The building is Indo-Saracenic, blending Mughal, Maratha and Jain elements, and stands among palms and formal gardens.



Fig. 01 — The museum from outside



03 · TIMELINE

Seventeen years from first stone to opening

1905

Foundation stone
laid by the Prince
of Wales

1907

The “Crescent Site”
granted for the
building

1909

George Wittet
commissioned as
architect

1915

Completed, then
used as a military
hospital in the First
World War

1922

Opened to the
public on 10 January

1998

Renamed after
Chhatrapati Shivaji
Maharaj

2010

UNESCO
Asia-Pacific
Heritage Award



04 · THE BUILDING

Two local stones and a Golconda dome

Three storeys crowned by a dome of white and blue-flecked tiles on a lotus-petal base, ringed by pinnacles with miniature domes. Wittet modelled it on the dome of Golconda Fort.



Kurla basalt, grey



Malad trachyte, buff

These two stones also set this essay's colours.



Fig. 02 — The dome above the palms



05 · INFLUENCES

Five traditions under one roof

Golconda Fort	The dome
Gol Gumbaz, Bijapur	The inner vaulted arches
Maratha wada	Columns, railings and the balcony
Jain temples	Columns of the central pavilion
Mughal palaces	Projecting balconies, inlaid floors



Fig. 03 — Arches and balconies of the central hall

06 · ARRIVAL

Stepping inside

Past the porch, a carved wooden staircase climbs under latticed screens, while arcaded passages run along the sides of the building.



Fig. 04 — The main staircase



Fig. 05 — Passage beside the porch



07 · GALLERIES

Long, quiet rooms of painting and sculpture



Fig. 06 — A gallery of paintings



Fig. 07 — A gallery on the second floor

Blue walls, a spiral stair, rows of glass cases



Fig. 08 — The spiral stair



Fig. 09 — Display cases under the arches

Thread and cloth as installation



Fig. 10 — Folded panels



Fig. 11 — A wheel of spools

Here fabric is shown not only as clothing but as material: folded, stacked and arranged into patterns of its own.

10 · THE TERRACE

Up among the pinnacles

From the terrace, a grille frames the pinnacles and miniature domes that ring the central dome, close enough to see the carving.



Fig. 12 — The terrace of the museum

A building the city chose to protect

Heritage status

Listed as one of Mumbai's most important heritage buildings.

UNESCO, 2010

Asia-Pacific Heritage Award for the conservation of the building.

Public and funded

Maintained through annual grants from the government and the Bombay Municipal Corporation.



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Thank you

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Photographs from the original ECS fieldwork at CSMVS, Mumbai.

